ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why Was Moshe Greater Than Every Prophet?

Derech Hashem 3:5:1-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 5, paragraphs 1-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 3 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The last chapter of Part 3

Derech Hashem has four parts: the Kadosh Barukh Hu; His relationship with us; the soul and how it relates to Him; and, starting soon, the misvot and the reasons for them. Part 3 began with the soul and its five levels, then climbed the levels of revelation: dreams, the use of holy names for good and for bad, Ruah HaKodesh, and prophecy. Now we come to the highest level: the prophecy of Moshe Rabbenu, "a whole different discussion".

Paragraph 1: a distinction the Torah makes

Prophecy exists on two levels: that of all the other prophets, and that of Moshe. The Torah itself draws the line, in Parashat Behaalotekha. Miriam and Aharon were troubled that Moshe had separated from his wife. They were prophets too and did not need to separate. Their mistake was to equate his prophecy with theirs.

Miriam and Aharon were true prophets, but like Avraham and the others: a prophet who must prepare for the encounter. While with his wife he is not preparing for prophecy, so there is no conflict. But God told them that Moshe is different. "I can appear to him at any time." He does not need to prepare, so God can come to him in the middle of anything, and therefore he had to separate.

Why the Rambam made it a principle of faith

The Rambam calls Moshe the father of all the prophets, and counts this among the Thirteen Principles of Faith. Why is it so fundamental? Not believing in the power of prayer is wrong, but it does not make one a heretic.

The Rabbi's answer: if Moshe were merely equal to other prophets, then any later figure could claim to be his equal and come to reinterpret or replace the Torah. Later religions made exactly that claim. Once we establish that no prophet will ever be like Moshe, before or after, the Torah he gave is immaculately clear and no one has the authority to change it. That is why the Ramhal devotes a whole chapter to it.

A participant asked how Miriam and Aharon failed to notice Moshe's level. The Rabbi asked to hold that question until the differences had been laid out.

Paragraphs 2-3: the first difference, asleep or awake

The Ramhal will set out four differences. The first: all other prophets receive prophecy in a vision or dream, as God says, "In a vision I make Myself known to him, in a dream I speak to him."

Do not confuse prophecy with dreaming. Hazal said a dream is one sixtieth of prophecy only in that a dream also brings some extra information; the experience itself is entirely different. Prophecy is a trance in which the person loses his physical being, and has no doubt about it. What the Torah means is that, as in a dream, the prophet is not in control of his body. If a prophecy came while he was awake, even in the middle of the day, he would fall down and sink into a deep sleep, *tardemah*, and receive it then. The reason, as learned before: the body is a barrier between the soul and the divine, so the body must fall away.

The Torah's first full description of prophecy shows this: at the Brit Bein HaBetarim a deep sleep fell on Avraham, "and behold, a dread, great darkness". However great Avraham was, his prophecy was like that of the other prophets, though of course each prophet had his own level.

For Moshe it was "face to face": as two people speak awake and conscious, so Moshe was awake and aware during his prophecy.

A participant asked how Yonah could hold a dialogue with God while unconscious. The Rabbi: as in a dream, one can converse, and on waking the prophet remembers every detail. Another participant cited the anointing of Yehu, where the officers ask "why did this madman come to you?" The Rabbi called it an excellent proof that prophets sometimes had their experiences in front of others, as Bilam did before Balak.

He also clarified the saying that prophecy was given to fools and children. It does not mean they have any prophetic capacity. Prophecy is a deep, intimate connection with God, which they cannot have. It means only that, just as a prophet sometimes knows the future, they may sometimes be given a flash of intuition.

Paragraph 4: the second difference, the lens

Even in prophecy, the other prophets did not see as one sees a friend, but as through many lenses, the image refracted again and again. And the mirror itself is not polished. The prophet has no doubt he is experiencing the Shekhinah, but it is diluted. Nothing physical is seen, of course; we speak of perceiving the presence of the Shekhinah. The polish of the mirror differs from prophet to prophet. Their messages, likewise, come through riddles and allegories that must be worked out, though in the end they are understood.

Moshe saw through one lens, and a polished one, and his messages came clearly, without riddles.

Back to Miriam and Aharon

A participant returned to his question: since the other prophets were asleep during prophecy, how could they see Moshe's state? The Rabbi agreed they would not necessarily have seen it. When the Torah says God spoke "to Moshe and Aharon", Aharon would be in a trance and unaware of Moshe standing beside him, but Moshe would know. Another participant noted that Aharon is occasionally mentioned first. The Rabbi found it an interesting point to think about.

Summary

- The Torah itself distinguishes Moshe's prophecy from all others, as Miriam and Aharon learned.
- The Rambam made this a principle of faith so that no later prophet could claim to replace the Torah.
- Other prophets prophesied only in a trance-like sleep; Moshe prophesied awake.
- Other prophets saw through many unpolished lenses and received riddles; Moshe saw through one clear lens.
- Prophecy is a deep connection with God, not merely knowledge of the future.

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